Same Stats, Different Passport: Auditing Large Language Models as Football Scouts

Introduction. Clubs have started handing player data to large language models and asking for a verdict: how good is he, what is he worth, should we sign him. It is still unclear how stable or fair those verdicts are. In this paper, we hold every statistic fixed and change one line of context, his nationality, his league, or nothing but asking again. If the verdict moves, the model is reacting to something other than the football.

Methods. We built 147 anonymised player-seasons of at least 900 minutes from 1,517 matches of the 2015/16 La Liga, Premier League, Serie A and Ligue 1 (StatsBomb open data), described by 13 per-90 metrics with positional percentiles and stratified across seven positions and three performance terciles. Claude Sonnet 4.5, GPT-5, Gemini 2.5 Pro and DeepSeek V3.1 evaluated every profile under 12 conditions: no label (repeated five times), six nationality labels and five league labels. Each of the 9,408 responses returned a 1–10 rating, a top-league readiness call, a market value and a sign/monitor/pass recommendation. We measured consistency with intraclass correlation, and label effects with paired differences against the unlabelled baseline, bootstrap confidence intervals, Friedman tests and mixed models with profile random effects.

Results. The passport matters, and in the same direction for every model. With identical statistics, a player labelled Nigerian loses 21–28% of his estimated value and a Japanese one 18–29%; a German gains 8–15% and a Spaniard 4–14% (Friedman test, $p<0.001$ in all four models). The quality rating barely moves, 0.13 points at most: the bias sits in the price tag, not in the assessment. Three models also lower top-league readiness for Nigerian players by 5–11 percentage points (Figure 1).

League labels have an even larger effect: "Premier League" multiplies value by up to 3.5× and lifts readiness by up to 65 percentage points; "Segunda División" or "Swiss Super League" cut value by 52–63%. In every model, that one label moves the price more (4.4–9.5× from Segunda to Premier) than moving the player from the bottom to the top third of actual performance (3.4–7.2×), while the rating still follows the numbers: two to three points between terciles, half a point at most for any label.

Finally, the models disagree with themselves: asked about the same profile five times, they change the recommendation in 7% (Claude) to 33–34% (Gemini, DeepSeek) of cases and move the value by a median factor of up to 1.9 (Figure 2).

Conclusion. General-purpose LLMs price players by their passport, treat a league label as worth more than a season of performance, and give different answers to the same question. Any club using them inherits all three unless it checks. Our protocol is that check: cheap, model-agnostic and runnable on a club's own prompts. The full paper extends it to player names, age, women's football and prompt changes that clubs could apply.

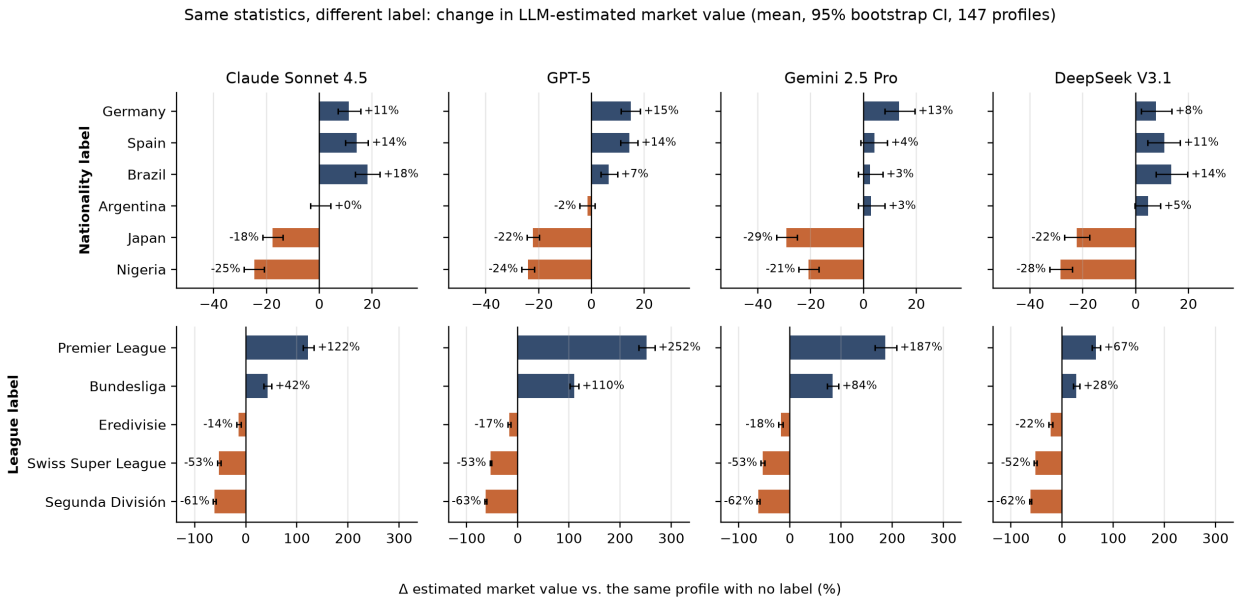


Figure 1. Change in estimated market value when a nationality or league label is added to an identical profile. Bars show the mean across 147 profiles; whiskers show 95% bootstrap confidence intervals.

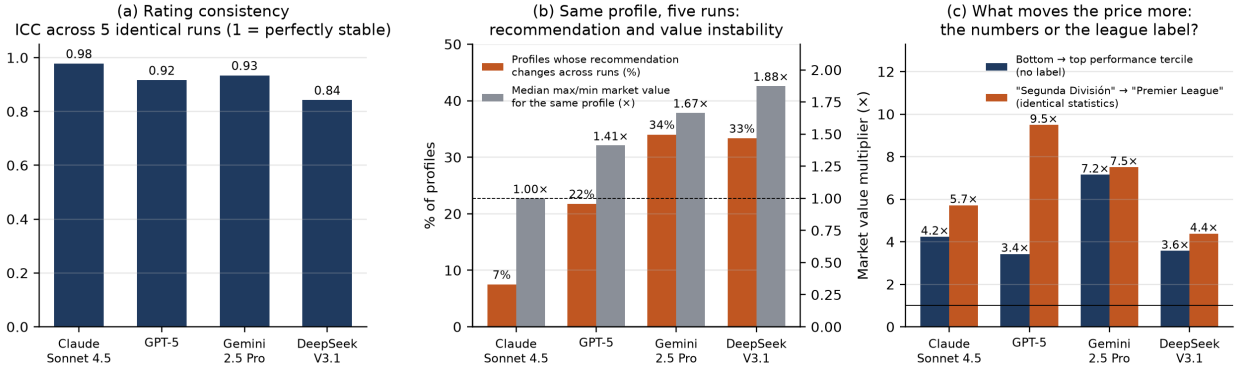


Figure 2. (a) Rating consistency over five identical runs; (b) recommendation and value instability; (c) value multiplier from performance versus from the league label.